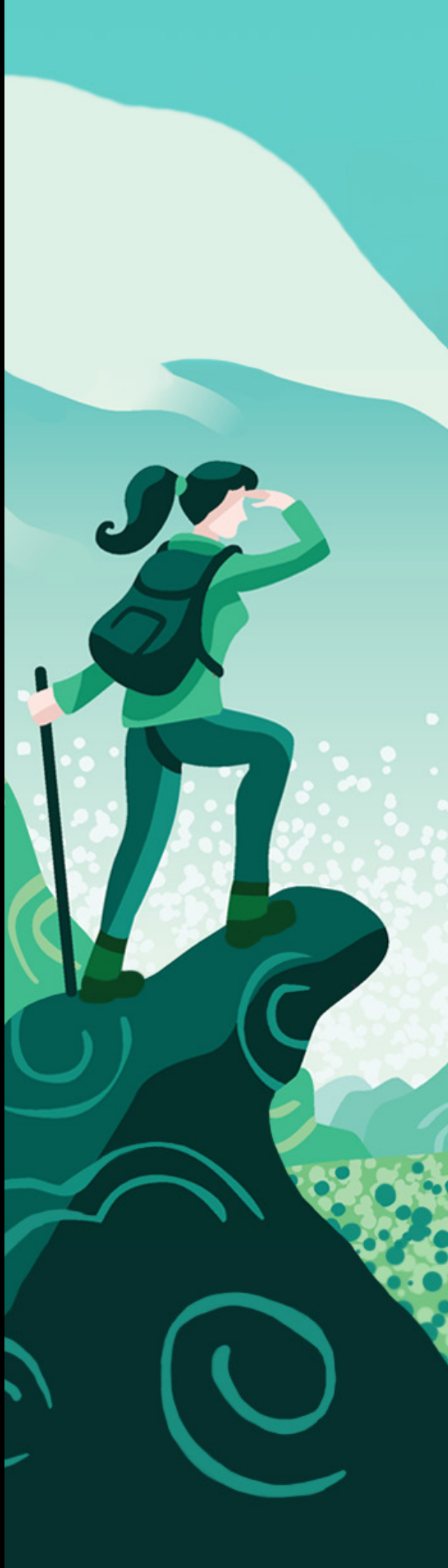
Forging Ahead

A look into the shifting landscapes of AI adoption, executive orders, compliance, tariffs, M&A and more.

State of Practice
November 2025



Bloomberg Law

Lawyers Are Warming to AI, But Slowly

By David Schultz

The use of AI is becoming increasingly common in the legal profession, with more adoption even since earlier this year, according to Bloomberg Law's most recent State of Practice survey of more than 750 respondents. But the survey also shows that skepticism of the technology remains strong.

More than a third of the legal professionals surveyed said they use generative AI at least a few times a week or more. When excluding partners and looking at just associates, that percentage climbs to nearly half.

Nearly seven out of every 10 law firm attorneys use generative AI for legal research to serve client needs, while only 40% of all attorneys used generative AI for legal research in general in our last State of Practice survey just six months ago.

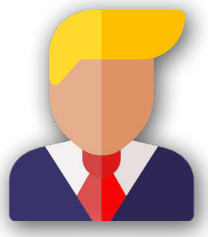
Jeffrey Gans, a partner at Pillsbury Winthrop Shaw Pittman, said he uses AI multiple times a day and was surprised these numbers weren't higher.

"It tells me that we still have a ways to go," he said. "When I hear people talking about its limitations, how it's not so great, how there are these problems, invariably part of that bias is because they simply haven't taken the time to understand the effort that needs to go into using it."

Indeed, almost a third of respondents predicted that, in one year, AI still won't be able to handle basic legal tasks like drafting contracts, managing discovery, or summarizing case law. Peter Smith, a partner at Fennemore, said lawyers are justifiably scared of AI introducing errors into their work.

"It absolutely terrifies us," he said, although he added that this fear should not stop lawyers from learning how to use AI responsibly. "I won't work with an associate unless they've been trained in it, and we had to take eight hours of training to be able to use it. So we were taught what its limitations are, what its strengths are, what the benefits are."

And Tiffany Means, a senior associate at Baker Botts, said she needs to be AI-proficient because all of her clients are already using it. "In order to provide them services, we have to be able to use AI," she said.
"I think, from that standpoint, all the partners understand that and are trying to be on the edge of that so that they can be on the same level as our clients."



One of the biggest developments in the legal world this year has been the Trump administration's attacks on some of the largest firms in the profession and the decision several of those firms made to strike pro bono deals with the administration to avoid being targeted.

Well over half of all attorneys surveyed said they would likely leave their firm if it struck a deal with the Trump administration. Additionally, more than 30% of attorneys said earlier this year that Trump's attacks were causing them to do less to publicize the pro bono clients they represent. Now, that number has declined to less than 18%.

"The firms that stood up are winning," Smith said. "It may have cost them time, energy, and access to top security clearance or whatever, but they're going to prevail in the end."

But he added that it's likely the firms that struck deals earlier this year genuinely believed the administration's attacks put them in financial jeopardy.

"It's really easy for us to look back and say we would've left if that would've been us," he said. "I think that's probably an unfair Monday morning quarterbacking of those folks."

Veronica Relea, a partner at Baker Botts who works on energy project finance, said she would be upset if her firm made one of these pro bono deals with the White House, but she wouldn't necessarily leave right away.

"I would seek to understand how the decision was reached, because not everything is open book when it comes to firm management making decisions," she said. "If and when I feel like the right move for me is to leave, then I would. But would I know right away? Probably not."

Another trend captured in the survey is the increasing workload for litigation attorneys. More than half of respondents said the volume of litigation work in their practices has increased compared to last year, while only 11 percent said it has decreased.

Gans, who works on construction and development projects, said that in his field, a worsening economy typically leads to more litigation.

"If there's money available to solve problems, that is usually the most efficient way," he said. "When money is tight, that money is not available to solve problems. And small problems become big problems and litigation blossoms."

More than half of respondents to this survey said they're responding to this uptick through hiring, while over a third said they're turning to technology in an attempt to automate some of this work.

Additionally, more than 60% of attorneys said their work on compliance issues has increased since this time last year. Many attorneys said their clients' compliance policies are getting stronger, particularly with regards to specific risks such as bribery.

Finally, the survey indicates Trump administration tariffs are starting to have an effect on attorneys who work on cross-border trade, as well as on mergers and acquisitions.

Around a third of M&A lawyers said the tariffs were slowing down deal negotiations and leading to more abandoned deals, while half of attorneys who work specifically on international trade issues said negotiations are now slower.

A similar number of trade and M&A attorneys said tariffs were requiring them to conduct more due diligence. In-house attorneys who work on this issue also said the tariffs are affecting them, with half saying they now are asked to do more advisory work on tariff-related risks.

Baker Botts' Relea said one silver lining of these trends is that the companies that are still eager to make deals in this environment tend to be more sophisticated, have longer time horizons, and are overall more willing to live with uncertainty. "There are some folks who are able to better navigate these times," she said. "And so the deals that I do see just tend, to me, to just be a bit more interesting."

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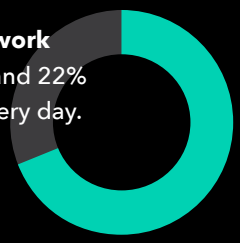
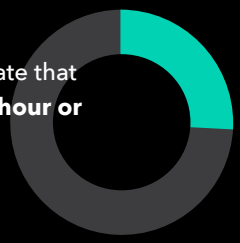
Data at a Glance

AI in the Workplace

7 in 10 use generative AI at work at least a few times every month, and 22% of attorneys use it at least once every day.

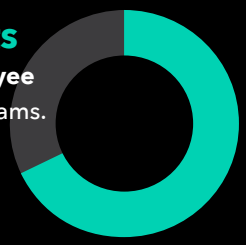


26% of attorneys estimate that generative AI tools **save them an hour or more** on work tasks each day.

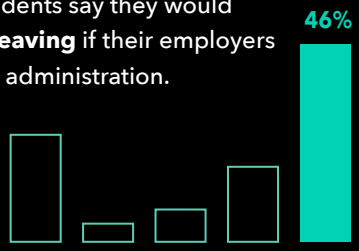


Executive Orders

68% have advised clients to **modify their organizations' employee resource group** or affinity group programs.



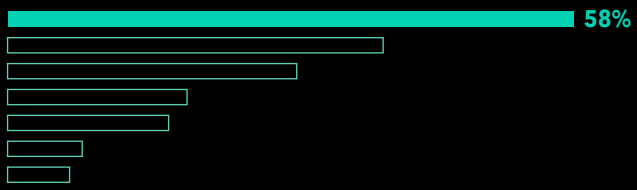
Nearly half of respondents say they would be **very likely to consider leaving** if their employers made a deal with the Trump administration.



Litigation

55% of law firm attorneys report an **increase in the volume of litigation** work in their practice compared to year ago.

6 out of 10 work at firms that **hired more people** to help accommodate the increased litigation workload.



Tariffs

Around 1 in 3 M&A attorneys say Trump's tariffs have **slowed down negotiations and deal timelines.** Just under a third also noted an increase in deals being abandoned.

Slowed down deal timelines

Slowed down negotiations

Increases in abandoned deals

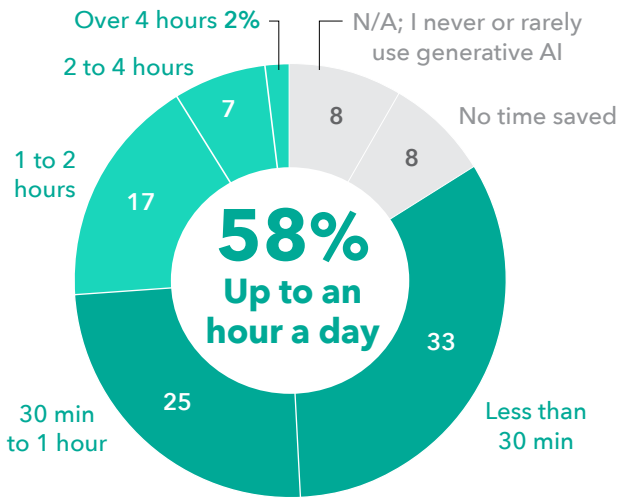
METHODOLOGY: This survey is drafted in collaboration with practice-area specific subject matter experts at Bloomberg Law. Data were collected in September of 2025 via online survey, with participation solicited through direct emails and posted anonymous survey link. Data are reported in aggregate with no identifying information retained, except to provide copies of this report. Legal professionals are asked to answer questions based on practice area and organization type. Most respondents are practicing attorneys, while some work with practicing attorneys in the legal profession or are in non-practicing alternative legal roles. Non-responses (e.g. "Don't know") are not always displayed.

Adoption of AI in the Legal Industry

How often **have you used generative AI for work** in the past six months?

Frequency	Overall	Associates	Partners
Never	**31%**	**30%**	31
A few times a month	31	24	**35%**
A few times a week	16	21	13
About once a day	7	5	6
A few times a day	9	12	10
Constantly	6	8	5

On average, how much time do GenAI tools **save you in your daily work tasks**?



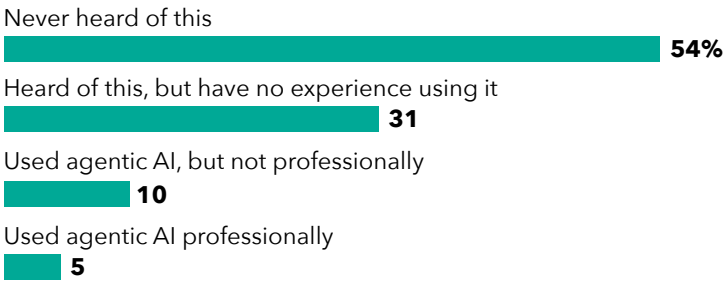
Lawyers' views on generative AI are, at best, mixed. Though many use it frequently and say it saves them time, others are unaware of the full extent of what it can do, while still others don't believe it will be able to handle basic legal tasks anytime soon.

More than two thirds of attorneys say they use generative AI at least once a month. Among those who use AI, well over half say it saves them up to one hour per day on average, and around a quarter say it saves them more than an hour per day.

However, **the majority of attorneys also said they've never heard of agentic AI,** where AI bots can independently perform tasks with little to no direction.

Furthermore, **a third of those surveyed said they do not believe AI will be able to responsibly handle basic tasks** like summarizing legal narratives, drafting communications, or even performing general legal research a year from now, despite the rapid development of AI technologies.

Which best describes **your use of agentic AI**?



Which of the following tasks do you think could be **responsibly assigned** to AI agents a year from now?

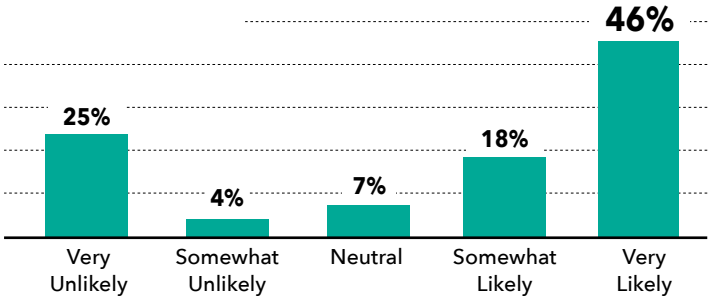
Summarize legal narratives (e.g., case law)	**39%**
Drafting communication (memos, emails, etc.)	**35**
Legal research in general	**32**
Draft/templating legal contracts	**32**
AI agents **won't be able to handle any task** in that time	**32**

Fallout from Trump's Executive Orders

> *The firms that stood up [to Trump] are winning. It may have cost them... but they're going to prevail in the end.*

– Peter Smith, partner at Fennemore

How likely would you be to consider leaving your firm or organization if it made a deal with the Trump adminstration?



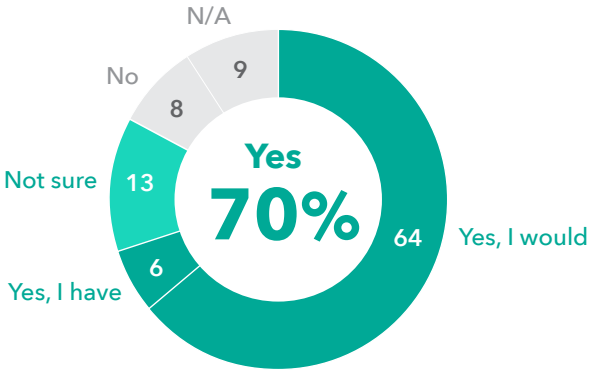
Attitudes among attorneys toward President Donald Trump's attacks on prominent law firms are shifting from fear to defiance.

Well over half of respondents said they would likely leave their jobs if their firms were to cut a pro bono deal with the White House. When focusing solely on associate responses, that number rises to 70% (compared to 59% of partners).

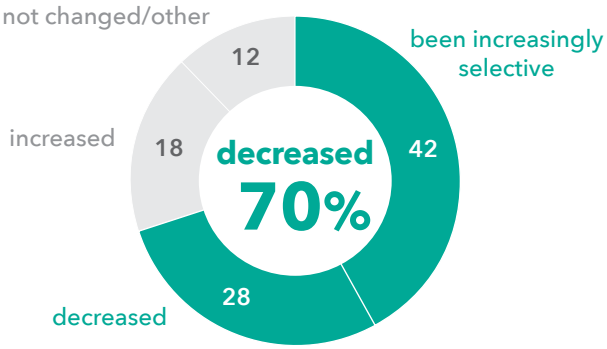
Additionally, **almost two thirds of lawyers said they would work on a case challenging Trump's executive orders** that targeted firms, while less than 8% said they would not.

Another consequence of the Trump administration is a perceived drop in access to the levers of power. A majority of lawyers who have lobbied in the past year reported that **access to key decision-makers has either declined or become increasingly selective**.

Would you work on a case that involves **challenging Trump's executive orders** or administrative priorities?

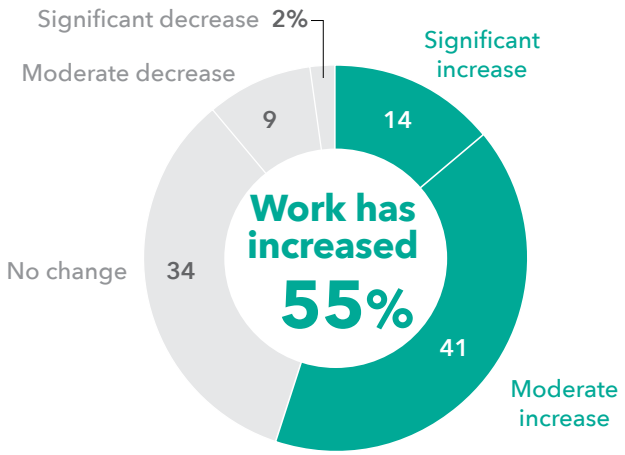


Those who have lobbied for policies or causes during this administration say **access to decision-makers has**...



The Rising of Litigation and Compliance

Compared to a year ago, how has the **volume of litigation work** in your practice changed? *(Law firm only)*



Which of the following strategies have your firm implemented to help manage the increasing demands of litigation?

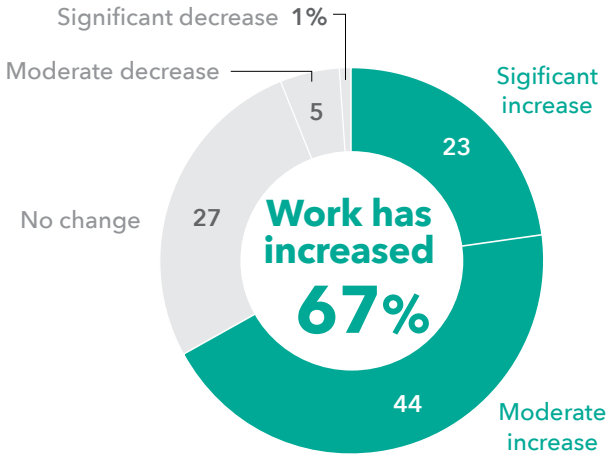
Increase hiring	**58%**
Technology adoption and automation	**39**
Training and skill development	**30**
Flexible **resource allocation**	**18**
Early **case assessment**	**17**
Restructuring the practice	**8**
Outsourcing and strategic partnerships	**6**
Other	**5**

Lawyers working on compliance and litigation matters say they're busier now than they were this time last year.

More than half of attorneys said there has been a moderate to significant increase in litigation work now, while less than 11% said litigation work hase declined. Attorneys responded similarly to questions about the volume of compliance work.

However, firms are responding differently to the increase in these two different types of work. **For litigation work, 58% said they were increasing hiring to handle the extra workload**. For compliance work, however, that number was less than 19%.

Compared to a year ago, how has the **volume of compliance-related work** in your organization changed?



Tariff Impacts and Mergers & Acquisitions

Around a third of M&A lawyers said the tariffs have slowed negotiations and led to more abandoned deals. Half of attorneys who work on international trade issues also said that negotiations are slower now.

Which of the following statements describes the **impact of tariffs on your M&A practice**?

Slowed down deal timelines	**36%**
Slowed down negotiations	**33**
Increases in abandoned deals	**30**
Increases in deal modifications	**23**
Accelerated deal timelines	**12**
Accelerated negotiations	**8**
None of these changes	*43*

The president's tariff policies are beginning to have an effect on the legal profession and its clients.

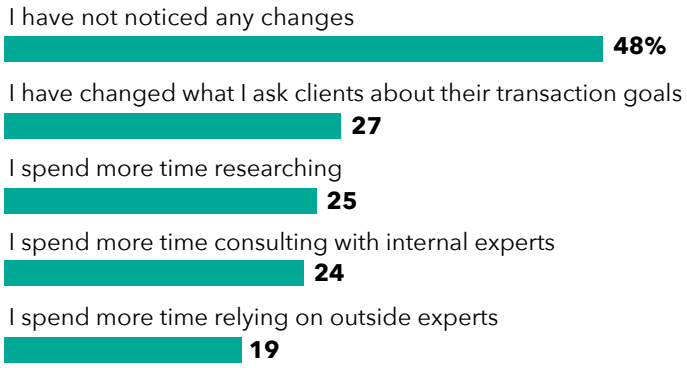
Over a third of M&A attorneys said the tariffs are slowing down negotiations and timelines for deals, while half of international trade attorneys indicate that tariffs are slowing down negotiations and contract executions in their line of work.

About half of M&A lawyers have made no changes in how they prepare their deals. Among those that did, **27% now ask clients different questions about their transaction goals**, and roughly a quarter spend more time doing research and/or consulting experts.

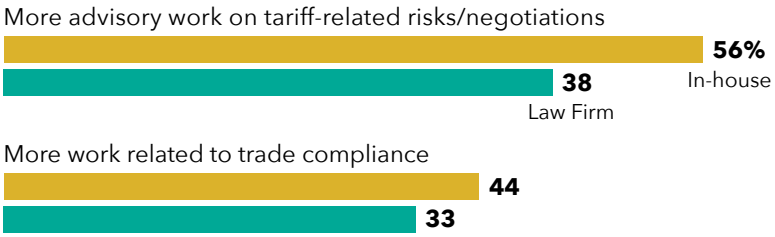
In some cases, in-house and law firm attorneys are experiencing similar effects of the tariffs, but to differing degrees.

For example, **56% of in-house attorneys say they're being asked to do more advisory work on tariff risks** and nearly 44% say they do more work related to trade compliance issues. For attorneys at law firms, these numbers drop to 38% and 33%, respectively.

How have changes to the regulatory landscape **affected how you prepare** to handle M&A deals?



How have tariffs **influenced the type of work** attorneys in your organization focus on?



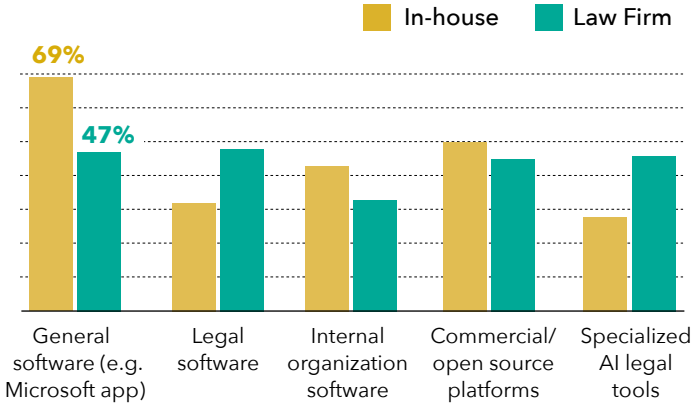
Additional Findings

Artificial Intelligence

Nearly half of respondents say their organizations adopt new technology **within the first year** of that technology being released.

After it's been **available for 6-12 months**	**25%**
Early adopters of new tech	**24**
Wait until new technology has been **well-established** in the market	**20**
Cautious adopters, **maintain existing systems** until upgrades are necessary	**17**
Mainly as a **response to client needs**	**13**
Other	**1**

7 in 10 in-house lawyers, and almost half of lawyers in general, use genAI tools for work that are **embedded within general software**, like Microsoft applications or CRMs.



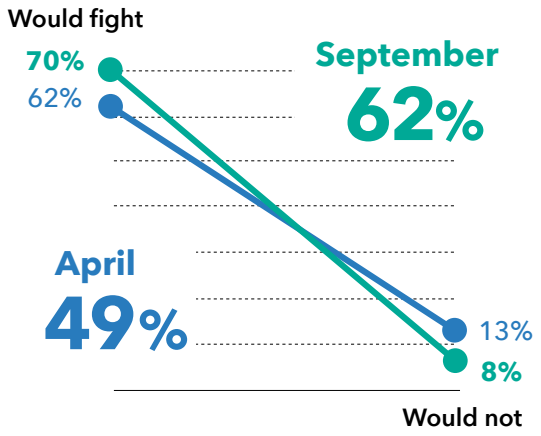
3 out of 10 attorneys, age **34 or younger, have used genAI for work a few times a week** in the past six months, the most of any age group. Not surprisingly, attorneys 65 or older have used it the least—with 42% reporting they have not used it once within that time.

	30 or younger	30-34	35-39	40- 44	45-49	50-54	55-59	60-64	65 or older
Constantly	15	10	9	9	10	13	1	5	2
A few times a day	5	10	11	9	10	11	10	7	6
About once a day	3	4	11	7	5	7	12	2	5
A few times a week	**28%**	**29%**	15	11	17	16	17	13	9
A few times a month	21	**29%**	**30%**	30	25	18	**36%**	**38%**	35
Never	**28%**	17	26	**34%**	**33%**	**35%**	24	35	**42%**

Additional Findings

Executive Orders

The gap between those who would fight executive orders and those who would not has **widened from 49 to 62** percentage points in the past six months.



The number of attorneys who say they **do less to publicize their pro bono clients** as a result of administration priorities has fallen by nearly 50% since April.

Effect on pro bono work	April	September
We do less to publicize our clients	**30%**	**18%**
Practice overall has increased	27	30
Increase in work representing marginalized groups	21	25
Decrease or end of work representing marginalized groups	16	13
Work has decreased/ended due to slashing of federal funds	5	5
We do more to publicize our clients	3	4

Compliance

Many attorneys say their clients and organizations have **strengthened their compliance policies** this year, most often related to specific risks like bribery.

Policies related to **specific risks** (e.g., bribery)	**76%**
More **frequent training**	**42**
Scope of investigations	**24**
Resource allocation	**21**
Staffing levels	**15**

Mergers and Acquisitions

Overall, 4 in 10 who do this type of work have **changed how they draft force majeure clauses** due to this administration's policies.

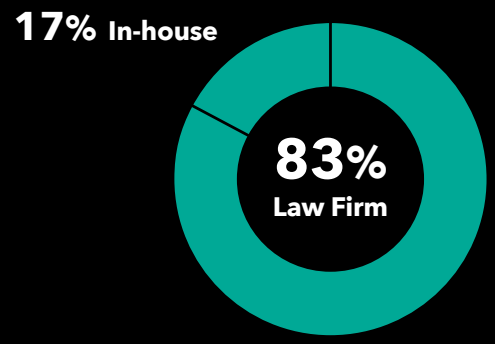
Inclusion of **language about tariffs** or trade sanctions	**28%**
Inclusion of **provisions for contract suspensions** as a result of trade policy changes	**21**
Separate **clauses to address trade policy** changes	**19**
More **specific timelines** to address trade disruptions	**14**
Renegotiation of **provisions in existing contracts**	**11**
I have not made any changes in this area	*59*

Respondent Demographics

Average Years in Legal Industry: 24 years

Average Age: 52.4 years

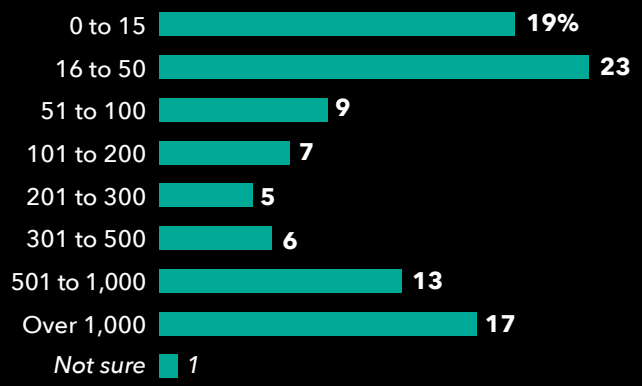
Organizations



Professional Title

Title	Count	Percent
Partner	304	**40%**
Associate	193	**25**
Counsel	187	**25**
Gen. Attorney	31	**4**
Other	41	**6**

How many practicing attorneys work for your organization? *(Law firm only)*



What is the annual revenue of your organization? *(In-house only)*

Revenue	Percent
Less than $40 million	**16%**
$40M to $99.9M	**10**
$100M to $249.9M	**4**
$250M to $499.9M	**5**
$500M to $999.9M	**9**
$1 billion to $4.9 billion	**13**
$5B or more	**25**
Not sure/Rather not answer	*18*

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